

TTTT3013

COMPUTER ETHICS AND SOCIAL

**MORAL THEORIES
AND
ETHICS PHILOSOPHY**



MORAL AND ETHICS PHILOSOPHY

- Moral Theories: Methods of Moral Decision-Making
- **Ethical Theory 1: Normative Ethics**
 - Virtue Ethics: Aristotle
 - Teleological/Utilitarian: Mill
 - Deontological: Kantian
- **Ethical Theory 2: Applied Ethics**
 - Computer Ethics

MORAL THEORY

1. Primacy of practice

- Ethics is a **department of practical philosophy** and thus primarily concerned with practical problems and action.
- The aim of moral argumentation, moral reasoning and judgement is
 - the rational justification and settlement of disagreement and conflicts about who one wants to be, what to do, the constraining of self-interest and the fostering of cooperation and peaceful coexistence of sentient creatures in a shared habitat

- Moral thinking **points to reasons** for constraining self-interested behaviour and self-serving strategies
 - We reflect upon and attempt to improve our moral beliefs and ideas with the end in view of finding answers to the question how to lead a flourishing life, how to act, decide and choose in such a way as to pursue our own happiness without interfering with the similar pursuit of others

The main **aim in ethics is** not to establish a general theory and a set of eternal truth but **to provide reasoned solutions and clarifications** to practical problems.

Therefore ...

- A moral theory is a set of statements used to systematize and codify our judgments concerning standards of conduct or behavior (Timmons 2002).
- Moral theories provide us with an account of what we should do (i.e., duties or obligations), what is good or worthy of pursuit (i.e., moral values), what is fair or just, and how we should our lives (i.e., virtue).
- Moral theories usually include general principles for making decisions in particular cases as well as definitions of morally relevant concepts.
 - For example, German philosopher Immanuel Kant's (1724-1804) moral theory includes definitions of dignity, autonomy, categorical imperatives, hypothetical imperatives, and good will (Timmons 2002).

MORAL THEORIES

TWO types of theories:

Theory	Description
Teleological (or goal-directed) theories)	Teleological theories hold that morality consists in promoting things we regard as valuable, such as happiness, knowledge, virtue, or human life
deontological (or duty-based) theories	deontological theories hold that morality is concerned with obeying moral duties. Deontologists claim that whether an action is right or wrong depends on the nature of the act, and its relation to our duties or rights, rather than the goals served by the act

Name of Theory	Type of Theory	Chief Proponent
Divine Command Theory	Deontological	Various religions
Virtue Ethics	Teleological	Aristotle
Natural Law Theory	Teleological	St. Thomas Aquinas
Utilitarianism	Teleological	John Stuart Mill
Kantianism	Deontological	Immanuel Kant
Natural Rights Theory	Deontological	John Locke
Pluralism	Mixed	W.D. Ross

ETHICS: PHILOSOPHY

- "the science of human duty; the body of rules of duty drawn from this science; a particular system of principles and rules concerning duty, whether true or false; rules of practice in respect to a single class of human actions; as, political or social ethics; medical ethics É" and today **computer ethics**.
- Ethics is the reasoning that we do in order to make decisions that will not violate our conscience.
 - As the Greeks would say, "to keep one's soul pure".
- Computer ethics tries to **clarify and provide solutions** to the **issues** that are raised by **computers** in areas such as **privacy, personal property**, damage to others' property, safety, and so forth.
 - Computer ethics falls in the area of *normative* ethics, that is the quest for the practical truth of how one's choices and actions will be good and worthwhile.

Methods of Moral Decision-making

- Methods of moral decision-making are concerned, in a variety of ways,
 - moral decision-making
 - people who make such decisions.
- Some methods focus on the **actions** that result from the choices that are made in moral decision-making situations in order to determine which of such actions are right, or morally correct, and which of such actions are wrong, or morally incorrect.
- Other methods of moral decision-making concentrate on the **persons** who commit actions in moral decision-making situations (that is, the agents) in order to determine those whose character is good, or morally praiseworthy, and those whose character is bad, or morally condemnable.

ICT have properties which make it difficult to make up our minds concerning the answers to the moral questions to which they give rise and it is certainly not the type of technology that we can decide to turn off or ignore should we become uncomfortable with its problems and results.

ICTs are

(1) *ubiquitous and pervasive* in a way in which our most common technical artefacts are not.

(2) ICTs are a *universal technology*, because of their 'logical malleability' (Moor 1985) – essence of Turing Machines

(3) a *meta-technology*, that is, a technology which forms an essential ingredient in the development and use of other technologies

ICTs are also (4) a *constitutive technology*. Computing technology co-constitutes the things to which it is applied

Furthermore, ICTs are about *information*

It is often not immediately clear that ICTs merit special attention and require moral evaluation and analysis

A safe starting point for moral thinking are:

- 1) to look simply at the **effects** the new entities have on people, the environment and on everything we endow with moral standing,
- 2) to turn to some of the **ethical theories** in the history of philosophy, such as Utilitarianism, Kantian ethics or virtue ethics

This is what computer ethics has done in the past three decades.

ETHICS: PHILOSOPHY

- Methods: Descriptive ethics, Meta-ethics, Normative ethics and Applied ethics.
 - Descriptive ethics: What do people think is right?
 - Meta-ethics: What does "right" even mean?
 - Normative (prescriptive) ethics: How should people act?
 - Applied ethics: How do we take moral knowledge and put it into practice?
- The theorists of such methods deal with such questions as:
 - which is the morally correct one to choose?;
 - What are the particular virtues of character that, in conjunction, constitute a good person?;
 - Are there certain human actions that, without exception, are always morally incorrect?;
 - What is meant by a specific moral concept?; and many others.

A CONSTANT IN ETHICAL DELIBERATIONS



Lack of
shared
vocabulary
for ethics



Put forward
an ultimate
argument
that takes
the form of a
principle



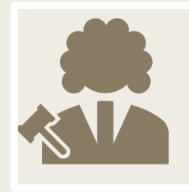
Need list of
fundamental
values

ONE OR COMBINATION OF THEORETICAL APPROACHES



Ontological approach:

search for full happiness, thinking about the purpose of life, man's place in nature, society



Narrative ethics:

bottom-up approach, concern for the context of life, local construction of meaning



Code of ethics:

professional's moral responsibilities, duty to ensure prevention

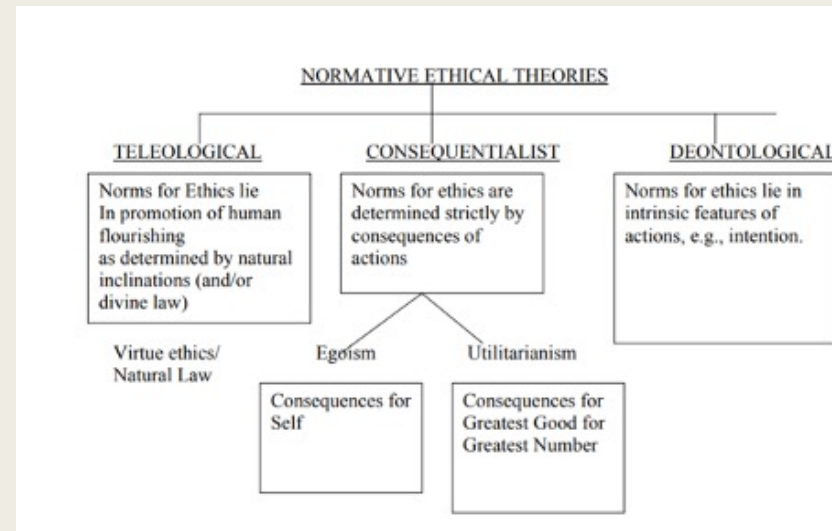
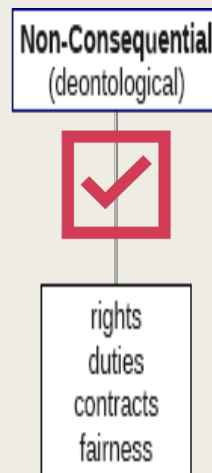
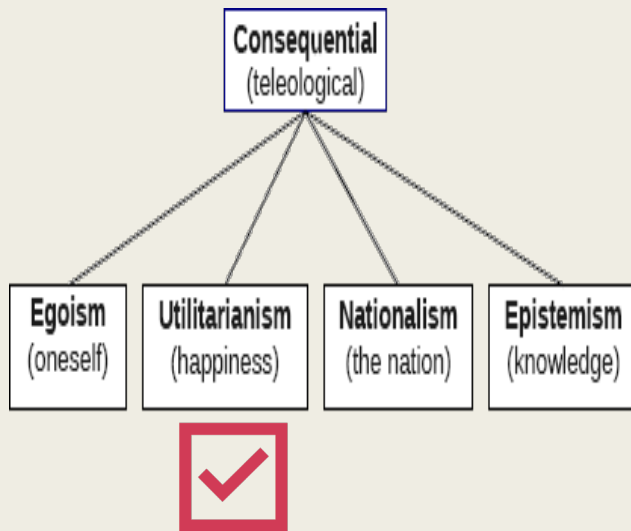
COMBINATION OF THEORETICAL APPROACHES

- Teleological: Utilitarian
 - Balancing costs and benefits (economic, health, social, political, etc.)
- Empirical and descriptive ethics:
 - take into account the main values of the populations targeted by programs
- Ethical relativism and pragmatism:
 - raise questions about ethnocentric and dogmatic biases in the principles and values chosen

ETHICAL THEORY 1: NORMATIVE ETHICS



NORMATIVE ETHICS



6

REASONS WHY CAN BE NORMATIVE

1 Can only follow an empiricist and relativistic ethics at the risk of adopting the attitudes of:

- the “Conservative thug”
- the “Complacent democrat”
- the influence of “moral communities,” lobby of “comprehensive egoism” (Steven Kautz)

2 Must be based on a premise of social justice: treating everyone equitably

3 The fundamental values and principles on which it will be based must be explicit, clearly identified and defined.

4 An implicit normative already guides decisions

5 “It is an illusion to think that what we say is not based on a moral orientation that we believe is just” (translation, Taylor 1998)

6 Government must be able to assume and defend the ethical positions it takes, whether they are conscious or not. “These challenges require an analysis based on an ideological or normative commitment” (translation, Guttman, 2000)

3 TYPES OF NORMATIVE ETHICS

1



Virtue Ethics:
Aristotle

2

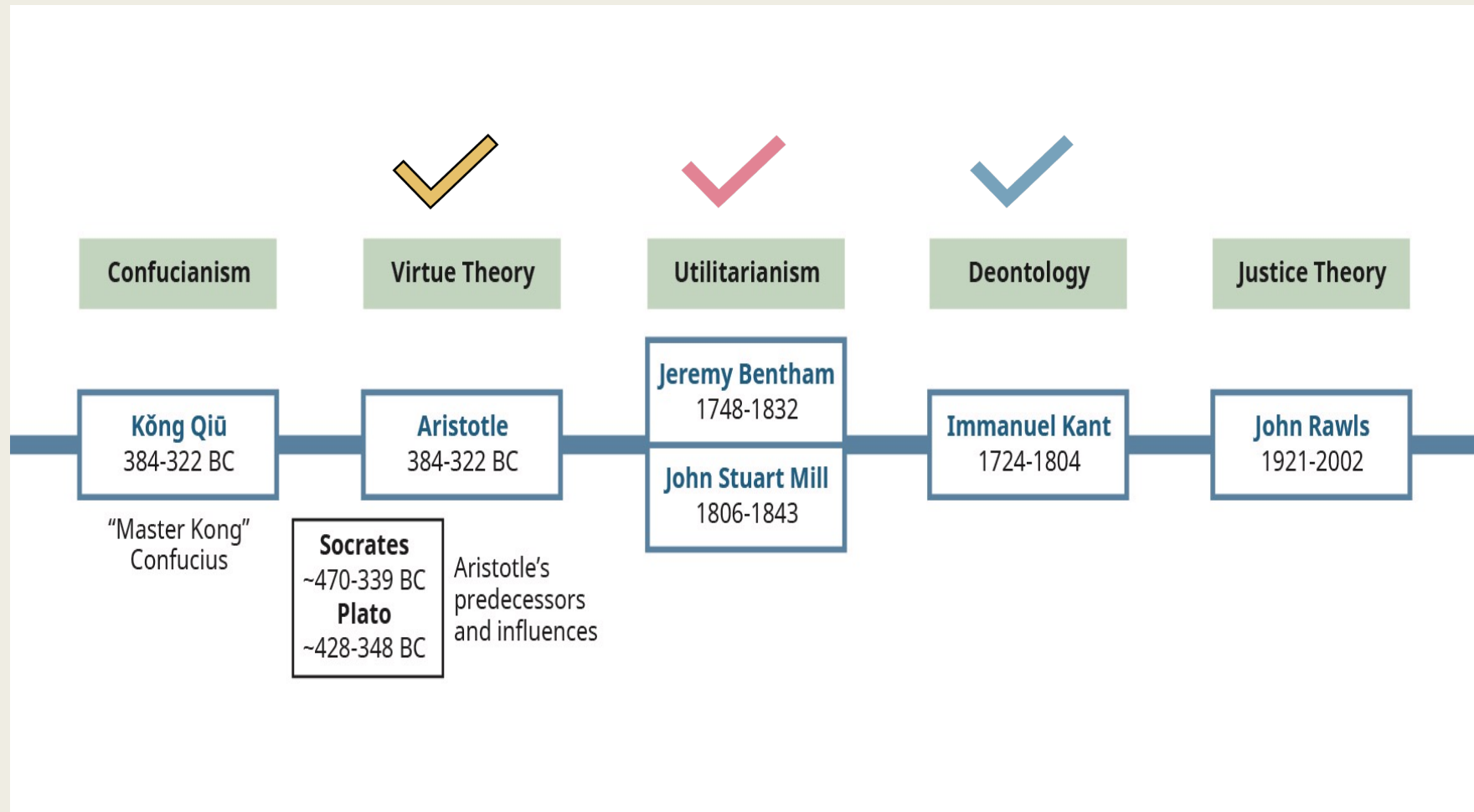


Utilitarian:
Mill

3



Kantianism:
(Kant)





TYPE 1: VIRTUE ETHICS (Aristotle)

- Aristotle's version of virtue ethics, has been one of the most **influential versions**.
 - According to Aristotle, a **person's character is the determinative factor** in discerning the extent to which that person is a good person.
- To the extent to which a person's character is reflective of the moral virtues, to that same extent is that person a good person.
 - Moral virtues include but not be limited to courage, temperance, compassion, generosity, honesty, and justice.

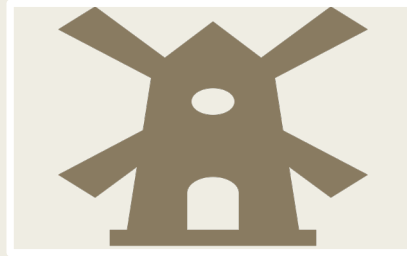
- The **person** in whom these moral virtues are to be found **as steadfast** dispositions can be relied on to **exhibit a good character** and thereby to **commit morally correct actions in moral decision-making situations**.
- For example, a **courageous soldier** will neither
 - run **headlong into battle** in the belief that “war is glory” nor
 - run **away from the battle** in the belief that he is afraid of being injured or killed.

Explanation:

- The former soldier has chosen to be “rash” during the heat of battle while the latter soldier has chosen to be a “coward”.
 - By contrast, the “courageous” soldier holds his position on the battlefield and chooses to fight when he is ordered to do so.
- The fundamental difference between the “courageous soldier, the “rash” and the “cowardly soldiers”:
 - only the courageous soldier actually knows why he is on the battlefield and chooses to do his duty to defend his comrades, his country, and his family while recognizing, the realistic possibility that he might be injured, or even killed, on the battlefield (Aristotle, 1985).

IN ICT:

- Virtue ethics is directly applicable to IT. To solve the issue of IS Trusted workers.
 - the problem of insider threats only limited success has been achieved in preventing trusted insiders from committing security violations.
 - Virtue ethics may be a new approach that can be utilized to address this issue.
 - Virtue ethics based concepts have the potential to influence and align the moral values and behavior of Information Systems workers with those of an organization in order to provide increased protection of IS assets.



TYPE 2: UTILITARIAN (Mill)

- John Stuart Mill, 19th century
- Mill articulated and defended a theory of morality that was designed to **prescribe moral behaviour for all of humankind**.
- Mill's utilitarian theory of morality :- **human actions, which are committed in moral decision-making situations**, are
 - determined to be morally correct to the extent to which they, on balance,
 - promote **more happiness** (as much as possible) than unhappiness (as little as possible) for everyone who is affected by such actions.
- **core idea is that whether actions are morally right or wrong depends on their effects.**
 - **Focussing on outcomes.**
 - **It is a form of consequentialism**

- **Conversely**, human actions, which are committed in moral decision-making situations, are : -
 - determined to be morally incorrect to the extent to which they, on balance,
 - produce more unhappiness rather than happiness for those who are affected by such actions.
- Mill hastens to acknowledge that the agent in the moral decision-making situation must count oneself as no more, or less, important than anyone else in the utilitarian calculation of happiness and/or unhappiness.

- Utilitarianism holds that the most ethical choice is the one that will produce the greatest good for the greatest number.
- It is the only moral framework that can be **used to justify military force or war**.
- It is also the most common approach to moral reasoning used in business because of the way in which it accounts for costs and benefits.



LIMITATION:

- we **cannot predict the future**, it's difficult to know with certainty whether the consequences of our actions will be good or bad
- Utilitarianism also has trouble accounting for values such as justice and individual rights.

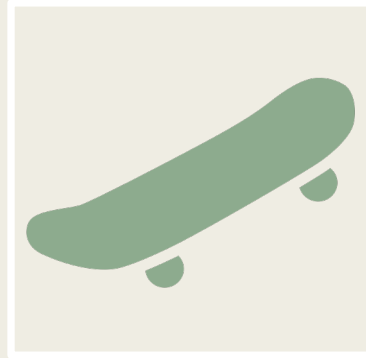
Example

- utilitarians ask: What is there that is intrinsically good? What is so valuable that we can use it to ground a theory of right?
- Utilitarians conclude that happiness is the ultimate intrinsic good, because it is not desired for the sake of anything else.
- Some utilitarians claim that everything else is ultimately desired as a means to happiness.

Example

for example, your career choice. Say you have chosen to study computer science to become a computer professional. Why do you want to be a computer professional? Perhaps you believe that you have a talent for computing, and you believe you will be able to get a well-paying job in computer science--one in which you can be creative and somewhat autonomous.

- Then we must ask, why are these things important to you? That is, why is it important to you to have a career doing something that you have a talent for? to be well paid? to have work in which you can be creative and autonomous?
- Suppose that you reply by saying that being well paid is important to you because you want security or because you like to buy "things" or because there are people who are financially dependent on you, and so on.
- In turn we can ask about each of these. Why is it important to be secure? or to have material possessions? or to support your dependents? The questions may continue or you may end them by saying you want whatever it is because you believe it will make you happy. **The questioning stops because it doesn't seem to make sense to ask why someone wants to be happy.**
- But the point that utilitarians want to make is that the series of questions about your desires will not stop until we get to happiness.



TYPE 3: KANTIANISM (KANT)

- Human actions are evaluated in accordance with principles of obligation, or duty.
- The most influential of such theories is that of Immanuel Kant, as his fundamental principle of morality, was first formulated as, “Act only on that maxim whereby you can, at the same time, will that it should become a universal law.”
 - In application to any particular moral decision-making situation, the agent is being asked to entertain the question of whether the action that one has chosen to commit is sufficiently morally acceptable to be sanctioned by a maxim, or general principle.
- In other words, the agent is asked to attempt to universalize the maxim of one's chosen action such that all rational beings would be morally allowed to commit the same action in relevantly similar circumstances.

Example

- Case of a man who stands in need of a loan of money but who also knows well that he will not be able to repay such a loan in the appropriate amount of time.
- The **maxim of his action** would be:
 - Whenever I find myself in need of a loan of money but know that I am unable to repay it, I shall **deceitfully promise to repay** the loan in order **to obtain the money**.
- To **attempt to universalize** this maxim,
 - this man would **need to entertain a future course of events** in which all rational beings would also routinely attempt to act on this same maxim whenever they might find themselves in relevantly similar circumstances.

- However, **as a rational being**,
 - this man would come to realize that this **maxim could not be universalized** because to attempt to do so would result in a contradiction.
 - For, if such an action were to **become a routine practice**, on the part of all rational beings in relevantly similar circumstances as those in this man's case, then those who loan money (either as loan officers for financial institutions or as private financiers themselves) would almost immediately wise up to the fact that people are routinely **attempting to borrow money on deceitful promises**, that is, with no intention to repay such loans.



The loaning of money would, at least temporarily, come to a halt.

As Kant points out - because of the contradiction involved in attempting to universalize this maxim, neither the promise (deceitful as it is) itself nor the end to be achieved by the promise (that is, the loan of money) would be realizable.

So, the fact that a contradiction results from the:

- attempt to universalize the maxim reveals the impossibility of the maxim being able to be universalized, and
- because the maxim cannot be universalized, then the man ought not to commit the action.

ALTERNATIVE DISPUTE RESOLUTION



- Another formulation of the same categorical imperative was formulated as,

“Act in such a way that you treat humanity, whether in your own person or in the person of any other, never as a means only, but always as an end.”

- According to this formulation,

Kant is calling attention to his belief that all rational beings are capable of exhibiting a “good will,” which he claims is the only thing in the universe that has intrinsic value, that is, inherent value, and because a good will can only be found in rational beings, they have a singular type of dignity that must always be respected.

- In application to any specific moral decision-making situation, the **agent is being asked to respect rational beings as valuable** in, and for, themselves, or as ends in themselves, and, thereby, to commit to the principle to never treat a person (either oneself or any other) as merely a means to some other end.
- To apply this formulation: - one ought **not to make a deceitful promise**.

Explanation:

- to make a deceitful promise to repay a loan of money in an effort to obtain such a loan is to **treat the person** to whom such a promise is made **as a means only** to the end of obtaining the money.
- To be faithful to this formulation of the categorical imperative is to **never** commit any action that **treats any person as a means only** to some other end (Kant, 1989).

IN ICT:

- Deontological theories and Kant's categorical imperative (in either of these two formulations), can be [applied](#) to any number of [issues in the practice of IT](#).

Example

- one can look to the Edward Snowden episode. He “blew the whistle.” Some respect him, calling him a hero; others disapprove of his actions, calling him a traitor. Is he defensible on ethical grounds?
- One might have heard these arguments: “Snowden is not the only one. There are plenty of other whistle-blowers,” or “If Tom, Dick and Harry can do it, why not Edward Snowden?” These arguments are based on the [concept of relativism](#)
- If one person thinks it is right to say Snowden is a hero, but another individual does not think so, the argument is pointless, as it allows two people to decide right and wrong for themselves. In the end, no moral distinction between the opinions of the two individuals can be made.

EXPLANATION:

- But Snowden is no ordinary worker; he is a professional, one who engages in a job that handles a highly sophisticated commodity—confidential information.
- He was an employee of the US National Security Agency (NSA).
- In this capacity, Snowden appears to be wrong and disloyal to his employer in stealing and disclosing confidential information without authority.
- However, while, as a professional, Snowden is expected to respect professionalism and observe his professional code of conduct, as a person, he has a duty to himself and his moral convictions.
- This duty-based argument is based on the [theory of deontology](#).
- So, as an employee, Snowden failed because he was disloyal and leaked confidential information. But, as a professional, he was right in exposing the stealth act because he was acting in accordance with professional conduct. While helpful in defending duty-bound actions, [this principle is inherently troublesome because the actor owes responsibility to the multitude of stakeholders](#), and each of the stakeholders has its own aims that may be conflicting with one another.

1 TYPE OF APPLIED ETHICS

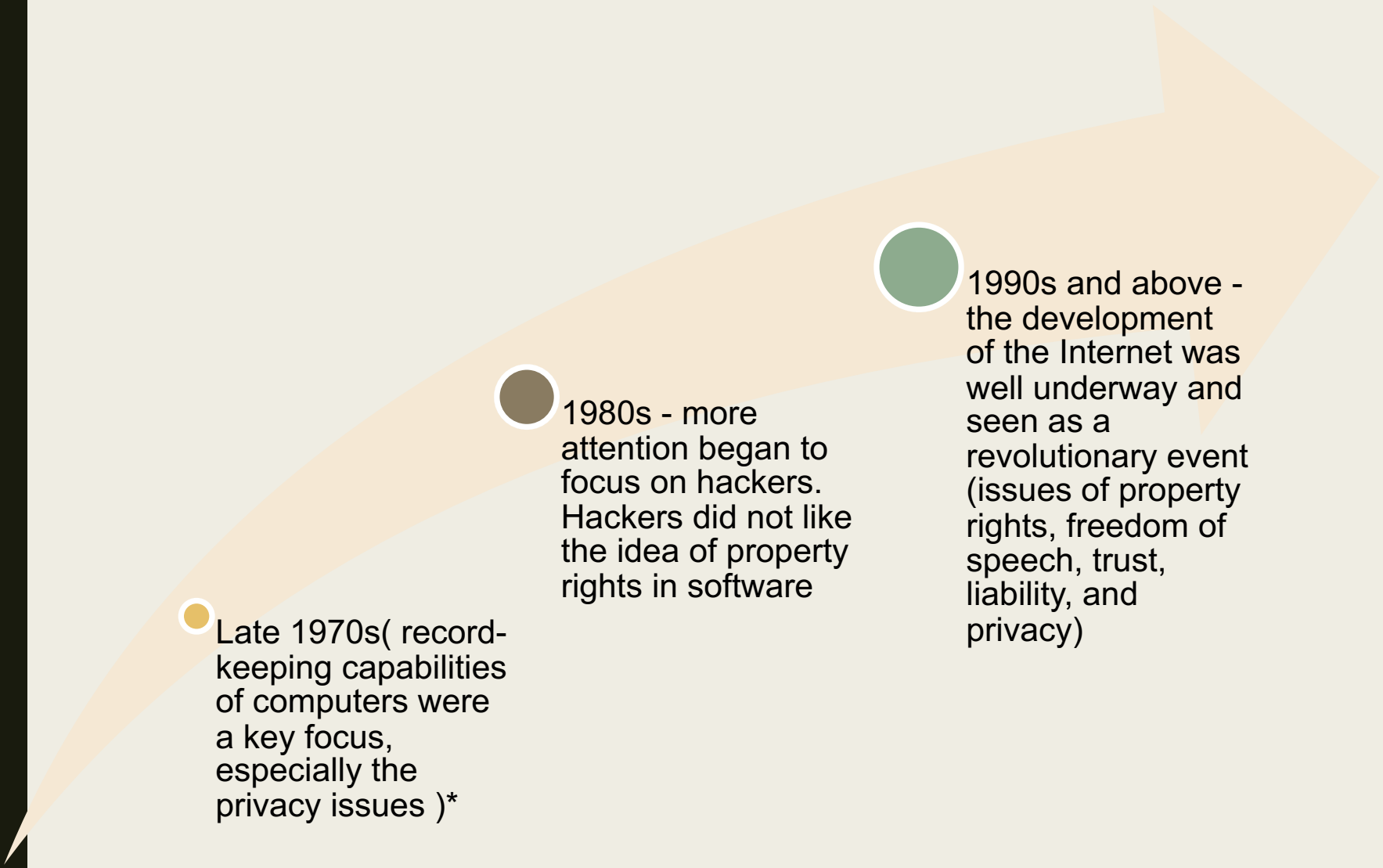


1 Computer ethics



COMPUTER ETHICS

- The origin of fascination may well be related to computers having been initially perceived and characterized as *thinking machines*.
- For centuries, human beings had been thought of as unique because they were able to *reason* and had the capacity for *rational thinking*.
- When computers were first developed and used, they seemed capable of being programmed to think in some of the ways that humans think; some believed they had the potential to become even more sophisticated and eventually reach or even surpass human intelligence.
- In that context, it was thought that computers would revolutionize the way humans think about themselves and what it means to be human



Late 1970s(record-keeping capabilities of computers were a key focus, especially the privacy issues)*

1980s - more attention began to focus on hackers. Hackers did not like the idea of property rights in software

1990s and above - the development of the Internet was well underway and seen as a revolutionary event (issues of property rights, freedom of speech, trust, liability, and privacy)

*The issues that took shape in this period were largely issues of privacy and the power of centralized government

SUMMARY OF NORMATIVE ETHICS

	Consequentialism	Deontology	Virtue Theory
Example	Mill's utilitarianism	Kantian's ethics	Aristotle's moral theory
Abstract description	An action is right if it promotes the best consequences	An action is right if it is in accordance with a moral rule or principle. Duty and responsibility.	An action is right if it is what a virtuous agent would do in the circumstances
specification	The best consequences are those in which happiness is maximized	A moral rule is one that is required by rationality	A virtuous agent is one who acts virtuously. That is, one who has and exercises the virtues. A virtue is a character trait a human being needs to flourish or live well



Teleological – considers the amount of good in the end,
consequence.



Deontological – focuses on the protection of individual and universal right, behavior rather than consequence.

Duty and responsibility.

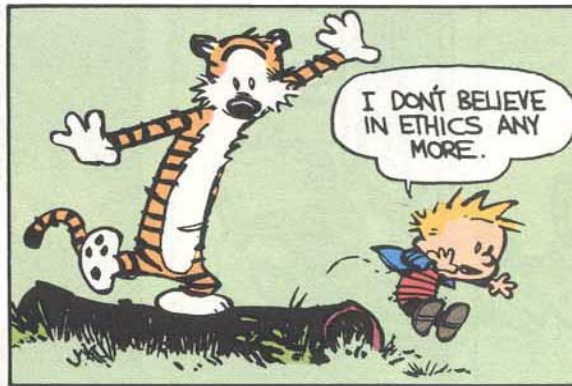
SUMMARY



Type of theory	FOCUS	USE	ADVANTAGE	DISADVANTAGE
Teleology/ Utilitarianism	Consequences	Conducting population level cost-benefit, risk-benefit, or cost-effectiveness analyses.	Stresses promotion of happiness and utility	Ignores concerns of justice for the minority population
Deontology	Dutifulness	Est compliance rules and regs, and setting standards for evaluating actions and behavior	Stresses the role of duty and respect for persons	Underestimates the importance of happiness and social utility
Virtue	Character / Agent-centered	Assessing skills and capacities needed for success in a community, org, or profession	Stresses moral development and moral education	Depends on homogeneous community standards for morality.

calvin and Hobbes

by WATTERSON



GET WHAT YOU CAN WHILE THE GETTING'S GOOD - THAT'S WHAT I SAY! MIGHT MAKES RIGHT! THE WINNERS WRITE THE HISTORY BOOKS!

